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**SEIZE THE DAY** Rahul Gandhi at the Congress rally in Khammam

TELANGANA/ CONGRESS

# A CAN-DO SPIRIT IN THE DECCAN

By Amarnath K. Menon

It has taken almost a decade for the Congress to recover from the mystifying coma it went into ever since Telangana was born. Although its ground presence was so entrenched and pervasive that it had never really vanished, a strange defeatism seemed to afflict it. Two-time chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao's party, now named the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS), meanwhile, claimed near-total ownership of state politics. But now, widespread speculation about a truce between KCR and the BJP-led government at the Centre has created just the opening the Grand Old Party needed.

Since it was Rahul Gandhi's brief foray into Telangana during his Bharat Jodo Yatra that offered the first glimpses of a new life, it was fitting that it fell to him to prophesise a rebirth. At a massive Jana Garjana (People's Roar) rally in Khammam on July 2, the Congress leader said: "Our victory in Karnataka was propelled by poor people and the marginalised, the farmers, labourers, youth, Dalits and minorities vexed with the misrule there. The same will happen here." He promised Rs 4,000 a month as pension to widows, senior citizens and disempowered groups if the Congress retakes its former bastion. The party, it seems, is finally getting serious about wresting the state that was signed into existence by one of the last legislations of the UPA government in 2014.

**THE INTERNAL SQUABBLES AREN'T A PRIORITY NOW, MORE PROOF THAT THE CONGRESS STATE UNIT BELIEVES THEY CAN WIN AGAIN**

A few happy coincidences play their part here: the Congress win in Karnataka has helped bring a spring back to the steps of the state unit. And as Telangana approaches its own election—due before December—the anti-incumbency from two terms in power seems to be weighing heavy on the BRS. Ruling party leaders disillusioned with KCR and his authoritarian ways have been eyeing the exit door. At Khammam, BRS leader and ex-MP Ponguleti Srinivasa Reddy, who has much clout in the region, joined the Congress. Ex-minister Jupally Krishna Rao is being named among those who may come on board at a roadshow in Mahbubnagar later this month. More inward migrations, including from the BJP, are on the cards.

There are other welcome signs for the party. The Khammam rally coincided with the conclusion of the 109-day statewide padayatra of the Congress Legislature Party leader Mallu Bhatti Vikramarka. In a style reminiscent of the late stalwart Y.S. Rajasekhara Reddy, the Dalit leader covered 1,360 km in 17 districts and 36 constituencies across the state, meeting people, listening to their woes and speaking about what the Congress would do for them.

In another shift, internal squabbles are on the backburner, which shows a degree of self-belief and purpose in the state unit. "A visible collective leadership is a welcome change in the Congress. While anti-incumbency and the BJP's seeming lack of interest in fighting the BRS are critical factors, the party is playing as a team after a long time," explains Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches political science at NALSAR University, Hyderabad. Moreover, the state's influential Reddy caste, probably sensing the unwritten BRS-BJP pact as something that may not help them in the long run, "is likely to align with the Congress". The Left parties, CPI and